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Messenger Poems

by Kali·dasa, Dhoyi
& Rupa Go·svamin



Translated by

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CONTENTS

Sanskrit alphabetical order	7
CSL conventions	7

MESSENGER POEMS

Introduction		13
Bibliography		18
Kali-dasa	The Cloud Messenger	21
	Part One	22
	Part Two	64
Dhoyi	The Wind Messenger	101
Rupa Go-svamin	The Swan Messenger	175
Notes		273
Index		281

A *sandhi* grid is printed on the inside of the back cover

PART ONE

1.1

A CERTAIN *yaksha*,* careless in his duties,
lost his powers through his master's curse.

It was to be suffered for a year
and separation from his sweetheart
made it unbearable.

He took to living in the hermitages on Rama's mountain,
their waters sanctified by Sita's bathing,
their trees giving lovely shade.

After he had spent many months
on the mountain apart from his lady,
that loving husband's golden bracelets slipped off,
leaving his forearms bare.

Then, on the last day of Ashádha,*
he saw clinging to the mountaintop
a cloud looking like an elephant
stooping playfully to butt a bank of earth.

Somehow managing to stand
before the bringer of blossom to the *kétaka* tree,
the servant of the king of kings
was lost in thought for an age,
holding back his tears.
At the sight of a cloud,
the mind of even a happy man takes a turn—
how much more so a man at far remove
longing for an embrace!

With the month of Shrāvana* approaching,
 he wished to give succor
 to his sweetheart's existence.
 Hoping that the cloud would carry
 news of his well-being,
 he welcomed it
 with an offering of fresh *kútaja* flowers
 and greeted it gladly
 in a voice full of fondness.

A cloud is a conglomeration
 of vapor, light, water and wind,
 and messages must be conveyed
 by living beings with keen faculties.
 Ignoring, in his enthusiasm, this incongruity,
 the *yaksha* made a request to the cloud—
 those consumed by love
 petition the sentient and the dumb
 indiscriminately.

I,5

“Born into the world-famous race of the Púshkaravártakas*
 I know that you are the chief servant of Indra the munificent,
 and can assume any form you wish,
 so I come to you as a suppliant,
 fate having taken my wife far from me.
 Better a vain request to one exalted
 than a successful plea to a wretch!

You are the resort, o giver of water,
 of those on fire with suffering,
 so take a message from me to my sweetheart,
 cut off as I am by the anger of the lord of wealth.
 You must go to the place called Álaka,
 the home of the *yaksha* chiefs,
 where Shiva lives in the park at the city's edge
 and bathes the mansions in the moonlight from his head.*

When you are risen to the way of the wind,
 wayfarers' wives will hold up
 the ends of their tresses to watch you,
 and take comfort from their confirmed convictions.
 On your appearance, ready to rain,
 what man could forsake a wife
 made miserable by separation?
 No one—unless, like me,
 his life were in another's sway.

Embrace and take leave of your dear friend
 this lofty mountain, marked on his slopes
 with lord Rama's universally adored footprints.
 When he comes into contact with you
 every rainy season,
 he shows his affection
 by giving off hot tears
 born of your long separation.

A favorable breeze is gently, gently
pushing you along
and this beautiful *chátaka* bird,*
greedy for water,
is cooing sweetly at you.
You are lovely to behold
and the cranes,
well acquainted with the rites of conception,
will doubtless line up in the sky
to wait upon you.

And if you go straight there
you will be sure to find your brother's faithful wife
alive and keenly counting the days,
for the heart of a lady is like a flower—
tender and tending suddenly to droop,
but supported in separation by the tie of hope.

And when they hear your thunder,
pregnant and melodious,
capable of bringing blossom
to the plantain trees of the earth,
flamingos eager for *Mánasa*,*
taking pieces of lotus shoots
as food for the journey,
will be your companions in the sky
all the way to Kailása.

Before you listen, o cloud,
 to my sweet-sounding message,
 first hear me tell you
 a favorable route for your journey,
 along which, whenever you are tired,
 you shall rest on mountaintops,
 and, whenever you are spent,
 you shall enjoy the wholesome water of streams
 before going on your way.

With your exertions watched in fearful alarm
 by simple *siddha* ladies*
 looking up and wondering
 whether the wind is carrying away the mountaintop,
 face north and rise up into the sky
 from this place and its succulent *nichula* canes,
 avoiding on your way
 the huge flickering trunks
 of the elephants of the quarters.

As spectacular as an array of brilliant gems,
 here in front of us part of a rainbow
 springs forth from the top of an anthill.*
 It will make your dark body especially beautiful,
 like the iridescent peacock feather
 that adorns the dark body of Vishnu
 when he is in his cowherd guise.

1.15

The harvest depends upon you,
 so the eyes of the country women—
 brows wet with joy
 innocently flirting—
 will drink you in.
 As they do so,
 go a little to the west,
 over the plain of Mala,
 fragrant from its recent plowing,
 before turning once more to the north.

When you have extinguished the forest fires
 with your downpours
 and are exhausted from your journey,
 Mount Amra-kuta* will duly support you on its peak.
 Mindful of past favors, not even a lowly man
 turns his back on a friend come for shelter,
 let alone one so lofty!

The mountain's flanks are covered
 in wild mango trees shining with ripe fruit
 and you are the color
 of a well-oiled braid of hair.
 When you surmount the peak,
 it will surely become a worthy sight
 for coupling celestials,
 looking as it will
 like the breast of the world,
 dark in the middle, pale all around.

After resting for a while on that mountain,
 its bowers enjoyed by forest-dwellers' wives,
 cross to the way beyond it,
 your gait quickened
 by the discharge of your water.
 You shall see Reva* scattered
 about the rugged rocky foot of the Vindhya,
 like a pretty pattern
 drawn on the body of an elephant.

Her water is *scented* : *infused*
 with the *fragrant* : *bitter* ichor of wild elephants
 and its flow is checked
 by thickets of rose-apple trees;
 after *disgorging your rain* : *vomiting*,
 you should drink it and move on.
 With water inside, *o cloud* : *o fat man*,
the wind : *wind* cannot disturb you.
 Emptied, everyone becomes lightweight;
 fullness makes for gravity.*

I.20

As you shower drops of water,
 the bees,
 on seeing the *kadamba* tree
 yellow and brown with its half-grown filaments,
 the antelopes,
 on eating the newly budding *kandali*
 along the riverbanks,
 and the elephants,
 on smelling the increasingly fragrant
 odor of the earth in the parched forests,
 will show you the way.*

I expect, o friend,
 that even though you shall want to hurry
 for the sake of my beloved,
 you will be held up on each and every mountain
 fragrant with *kútaja* flowers—
 watery-eyed peacocks
 will greet you with cries of welcome.
 Please somehow try to go quickly!

When you draw near to the country of Dashárna,
 its garden hedges will turn white
 with open-tipped *kétaka* buds,
 the sacred trees in its villages will be busy
 with the nest-building of crows
 who live off the household offerings,
 the forests of rose-apple on its outskirts
 will darken with ripe fruit
 and the flamingos will stay for a few days.*

The name of its capital, Vídisha,
 is famous everywhere.
 Immediately upon reaching there,
 you will obtain in full the reward of being a lover:
 you shall drink Vétravati's delicious waters.
 Your thundering near her banks
 will have enriched them,
 and in their ripples
 her face will seem to frown.

You should stop to rest there
on the mountain called Nichais.
When its *kadamba* trees thrust forth their flowers,
it will seem as if the mountain's hair
is thrilling at your touch,
and with its grottoes pouring forth fragrances
used by courtesans for lovemaking,
it proclaims the brazen youth of the citizens.

Once you are rested, move on,
sprinkling the jasmine buds
growing in groves on the forest rivers' banks,
with drops of fresh water.
When they wipe away the sweat from their cheeks,
the ladies collecting flowers
bruise the lotuses on their ears,
making them wilt.
In granting shade to their faces,
you will be momentarily appreciated.

Although out of your way
on your journey to the north,
you must not miss the lovely terraces
of Ujjain's mansions.
If you fail to enjoy the eyes
of the ladies in that city—
flickering and fearful
at your garland of lightning,
their corners aquiver—
you will have cheated yourself!

On the way, when you reach the Nirvindhya,
 her girdle-string a row of birds calling out
 at the tossing of her waves as she slips by,
 stumbling delightfully,
 her navel showing itself in her whirlpools,
 take her *water on board : affection to heart*,
 for playfulness is a woman's first expression
 of fondness for a sweetheart.

When you leave that river behind,
 her meager waters will become
 like a braid of hair
 and her complexion will grow pale
 with dead leaves falling
 from the trees on her banks.
 Lucky you!
 She is showing her affection for you
 through her lovelorn condition—
 only you can do what must be done
 to stop her being so thin.

On reaching the land of Avánti,
 its village elders expert tellers of tales of Údayana,
 go to the city just mentioned,
 magnificent Vishála,*
 which is as if inhabitants of paradise,
 on returning to earth
 with the rewards of their good deeds almost spent,
 have used the last of their merits
 to seize a single, beautiful fragment of heaven.

1.30

In the mornings there,
 the breeze from the Shipra,
 drawing out the shrill, drunken warble of the cranes,
 is fragrant from union
 with the scent of opened lotuses.
 Agreeable on the body,
 it takes away the ladies' languor after lovemaking
 like a sweet-talking suitor soliciting favors.

Wearied by your journey,
 you should spend the night there
 atop mansions fragrant with flowers
 and marked with red dye
 from the feet of lovely ladies.
 Your body will be engorged
 with the scented smoke for dressing hair
 pouring forth from lattice-windows,
 and the peacocks on the houses
 will, with brotherly affection,
 give you their dancing as offerings.
 Then, under the *ganas*' respectful gaze—
 for you are the color of their master's throat—
 you should proceed to the sacred home of Chandéshvara,*
 the teacher of the three worlds,
 where the gardens are fanned
 by breezes from Gándhavati
 scented with water-lily pollen
 and pungent from the bathing
 of the maidens who love to sport in her water.

Even if, o cloud, you reach Maha·kala
 at some other time of day,
 you must stay there
 until the sun comes into view.
 Playing the praiseworthy part of the drum
 in Shiva's morning worship,
 you shall reap in full
 the reward for your rolling thunder.

Belts tinkling as they plant their feet,
 hands weary from daintily waving
 fly whisks with handles
 encrusted in lustrous gems,
 the dancing girls there,
 on receiving from you
 the first drops of rain
 to soothe their scratches,
 will throw you side glances
 as long as a line of bees.

1.35

Next, at the start of Pashu·pati's dance,*
 remove his desire for a moist elephant skin
 by wrapping yourself around
 the tall forest of his tree-like arms
 and taking on the dusky red glow
 of a fresh china rose.
 Her eyes stilled
 by the alleviation of her anxiety,
 Bhaváni will behold your devotion.

At night, when the royal highway there
 is obscured in pitch darkness,
 show the way to the women
 going to their lovers' houses
 with lightning lovely
 as a golden streak across a touchstone.
 But don't be noisy
 with your downpours and thunder—
 they are nervous!

You should pass the night
 on some rooftop where pigeons sleep,
 your wife lightning exhausted
 from her long *lovemaking* : *display*,
 before continuing with your journey
 when the sun appears again.
 They do not dawdle
 who have promised to help their friends.

At that hour, lovers must appease
 their abandoned wives' watery eyes,
 so quickly get out of the way of the sun,
 for he, too, will be returning
 to remove a dewy tear
 from the lotus face of the lily,
 and if you obstruct his *rays* : *hands*
 he will be not a little annoyed.

You are handsome by nature
 and, if only in the form of your reflection,
 shall gain entry into the clear water
 of the River Gambhíra
 as if it were her happy heart:
 you should not be so unfeeling
 that you make her lily-white glances—
 the leaps of the darting *sháphara* fish—
 come to naught.

Her dark-blue robe, the water,
 has slipped from her hips, the banks,
 and reached the reeds
 as if barely held up in her hands.
 On removing it, my friend,
 you will be weighed down
 and struggle to journey on:
 who can leave naked thighs
 after tasting their delights?

Contact with the smell of earth
 swollen by your showers
 has made the cool wind delicious.
 While elephants drink it in
 with sweet sounds from their trunk-tips,
 it will gently blow you
 the way you want to go—
 toward Deva-giri—
 and ripen the wild figs.

Skanda* has taken up permanent residence there.
 Turn yourself into a cloud of blossoms
 and bathe him with showers of flowers
 wet with the water of the celestial Ganga,
 for he is that very blazing energy,
 brighter than the sun,
 which Shiva, the bearer of the new moon,
 cast in the mouth of Agni
 to protect the armies of Indra.

Out of love for her son,
 Bhaváni puts next to the lily in her ear
 a brightly ringed tail feather
 fallen from the fire-born god's peacock,
 whom, the corners of its eyes
 bathed in light from Shiva's moon,
 you should now make dance
 with thunder resounding in the mountain.

After worshipping in this way
 the god born in a reed thicket,
 journey on a little, your way abandoned
 by lute-carrying *siddha* couples scared of raindrops,
 before hanging down to pay your respects
 to Ranti-deva's glory,
 which was born of his sacrifices of Súrabhi's daughters*
 and took earthly form as a river.

I.45

When you, the thief of Krishna's complexion,
 bend down to take the water of that river,
 the sky-rangers will turn their gazes
 all the way to her stream,
 which, though broad, will look slender from afar,
 like a single string of pearls worn by the earth,
 a huge sapphire in its middle.

Cross that river and continue,
 making Dasha-pura's ladies
 gaze curiously upon your image
 with eyes expert at the flirtatious gestures
 of creeper-like brows,
 revealing their iridescence
 with an upward flick of the lashes
 and stealing the splendor of the honeybees
 following the fluttering jasmine flowers.

Plunging down with your shadow
 into the country of Brahma-varta,
 you should go to the field of the Kurus,
 redolent of the warriors' battle,
 where the wielder of Gandíva
 rained hundreds of sharp arrows
 on the heads of the princes
 just as you rain downpours on lotuses.*

When you take on Sarásvati's waters,
 which were drunk by the plow-bearer*
 after brotherly love had made him
 turn his back on battle
 and he had given up the wine
 marked with the reflection of Révati's eyes
 that he so cherished,
 you, too, kind sir, will become pure within,
 dark only in color.

From there you should go to Kana-khala
 and visit Jahnu's daughter,*
 she who came down from Himálaya
 as a stairway to heaven for the sons of Ságara.
 When she grabbed Shambhu's hair,
 her waves like hands as they clung to the moon,
 with her foam she seemed to laugh
 at the frown that appeared on Gauri's face.

1.50

If you should think to drink
 her crystal-clear water
 and twist down like a celestial elephant,
 its forequarters hanging from the sky,
 then, with your reflection
 suddenly gliding along her stream
 and her confluence with Yámuna*
 seeming to happen out of place,
 she would be beautiful.

When you reach the source of that same river—
 a mountain white with snow,
 its rocks fragrant from the musk
 of the deer that sit on them—
 and rest on its peak
 to shake off the fatigue of the journey,
 you shall look lovely,
 like the mud dug up
 by the bull of the three-eyed god.*

If the wind blows and wildfire
 born of the rubbing of *sárala* branches
 should consume with its sparks
 the yaks' bushy tails
 and plague the mountain,
 you must extinguish it completely
 with myriad downpours:
 it is by soothing the pain of the vexed
 that the riches of the most high bear fruit.

*Shárabhas** unable to bear your thundering
 will arrogantly leap up at you there,
 only to injure themselves—
 you are unassailable.
 Hail down your raucous laughter
 and scatter them,
 for is not everyone
 who strives at vain ventures
 an object of scorn?

On a rock there
is a clear imprint of the footprints
of he whose crown is the half-moon,
to which *siddhas* are constantly making offerings
and which you should circumambulate,
bowing with devotion.
When the faithful see it,
they are absolved of their sins after they die
and are destined for a permanent place in Shiva's troop.

Filling with wind,
bamboo canes sound sweetly
and beautiful celestial maidens
hymn the victory over the three cities.
If you were to echo
like a booming drum
in the caves there,
Shiva's orchestra would surely be complete!

Passing beyond the various wonders
around the flanks of the Himálaya,
you should head north,
through the flamingos' gateway—
the cleft of Kráuncha,
which was Párashu-rama's* path to glory—
splendidly stretching askance
like the dark foot,
ready to push down Bali,
of Vishnu.*

You should journey on
 and be the guest of Mount Kailása,
 the mirror of the wives of the gods.
 Its passes were torn asunder
 by the arms of Rávana,
 and, stretching across the sky
 with its lily-white lofty peaks,
 it looks like the wild laughter
 of the three-eyed god
 piled up night after night.*

You have the hue of gleaming powdered antimony,
 and when you reach the skirts of that mountain
 as white as a freshly cut piece of ivory,
 it will surely become stunningly lovely,
 like the plow-bearer wearing
 his black robe across his shoulders.*

And if Shiva were to cast off
 his dark snake-bracelets
 and hold Gauri's hand
 while she wanders on foot
 about that mountain of fun,
 you should arrange your body
 into a series of waves
 and steady the water within,
 becoming a stairway soft on the feet
 for her to climb.

1.60

Were you to go in there
 and start to pour forth water,
 the divine damsels are sure
 to make you their shower-bath.
 You will arrive there in the hot season,
 and if, my friend, you cannot escape them,
 you should terrify those fun-loving girls
 with your raucous thunder.

Taking on the water of Lake Mánasa,
 which bears forth golden lotuses,
 gladly giving Airávana
 the fleeting pleasure of a cover for his face,
 fanning with misty breezes
 the gossamer on the wish-fulfilling trees,
 you should enjoy that mountain bright as crystal
 in different guises.

When, o wanderer at will,
 you see her in the lap of the mountain
 as if in that of a lover,
 her shawl the Ganga slipping off,
 you will not fail to recognize Álaka:
 at the time of your coming,
 she wears in her soaring palaces
 a mass of clouds raining water,
 just as a lady in love wears her hair
 entwined with strings of pearls.

PART TWO

WHERE, WITH their various wonders,
the mansions are your equal:
you have your lightning,
 they their lovely ladies;
you have your rainbows,
 they their colorful pictures;
 drums are beaten in them to make music,
you have your gentle rumble;
you have water inside,
 they have floors made of jewels;
you are lofty,
 their turrets kiss the clouds.

Where the ladies have in their hands
lotuses to play with,
young jasmine flowers
woven into their hair,
radiant complexions
blanched by the pollen of *rodhra* flowers,
fresh *kurábaka* blossoms
in their topknots,
pretty *shirísha* blooms
in their ears,
and, in their hair-partings,
kadámba flowers born of your arrival.*

2.65

Where *yakshas* accompanied by the finest ladies
frequent palace terraces fashioned from crystal,
their flower-decorations the reflections of stars,
and drink aphrodisiac wine
sprung from the wish-fulfilling tree
to the gentle beating of drums
whose rumbling is as deep as yours.

Where the removal of your veil
brightens the moonbeams,
making the moonstones
hanging from webs of thread
ooze water globules
to relieve the languor
born of lovemaking
of ladies suffering
from their lovers' clutches.

Where, driven by the ever-moving wind
to the top floors of the palaces,
clouds like you damage pictures
with their raindrops,
and, seemingly seized with fear,
skillfully imitate streams of smoke
by falling apart and fleeing
through the lattice-windows.

Where impassioned, nimble-fingered beaux
 pull off the silk robes, already loosened
 by the untying of their knotted cords,
 of *yaksha* girls, who,
 befuddled by embarrassment,
 vainly fling fistfuls of powder
 at tall-flamed lamps lit by jewels.

Where the shaking of their gait
 leaves the nightly tracks of amorous ladies
 marked at sunrise
 by *mandāra* flowers
 fallen from their hair,
 by decoratively trimmed golden lotuses
 slipped from their ears
 and by snapped necklaces,
 the pearls on whose threads
 are infused with scent from their breasts.

2.70

Where, knowing that Shiva
 lives there in person,
 the fearful god of love
 tends not to carry
 his bee-stringed bow.
 The coquettish gestures
 of artful ladies
 do his job,
 their unerring glances
 sent forth by arched brows
 to their targets, the beaux.

Our home there, to the north
 of the house of the lord of wealth,
 is recognizable from afar
 by its arched gate,
 as beautiful as a rainbow,
 near to which,
 nurtured by my beloved like a son,
 is a young *mandára* tree,
 bent over with clusters of blossoms
 in reach of one's hand.

The tank there has emerald-paved steps
 and is crisscrossed
 by blooming golden lotuses,
 their stalks of gleaming beryl.
 The flamingos that have taken up residence in its water
 have lost their longing:
 even on seeing you
 they have no thoughts for nearby Lake Mánasa.

To the side of the tank,
 its top covered in exquisite sapphires,
 is a rockery, beautiful with its girdle of golden plantains.
 My wife is fond of it,
 so, friend, when I look at you,
 lightning flashes sparkling at your edges,
 it is with troubled mind
 that I think of it and nothing else.

On it, near a *mádhavi* bower
 ringed by *kúrabaka* bushes,
 are a red *ashóka* tree with waving fronds
 and a lovely *bákula*.*

In company with me,
 the former longs for the touch
 of your lady friend's left foot
 and the latter, feigning a craving,
 wants the wine of her mouth.

And between them is a golden perch
 with a platform of crystal,
 inlaid at its base with gems
 that shine like young bamboo.
 Your blue-throated friend, the peacock,
 roosts on it at day's end
 and my sweetheart makes him dance
 with claps made lovely by her tinkling bracelets.

By means, o clever one,
 of these signs stored in your heart,
 and on seeing the beautiful forms
 of the conch and the lotus
 inscribed around the door,
 the house is to be recognized,
 its luster now surely dimmed by my absence—
 at the setting of the sun,
 does not the lotus lose its beauty?

Quickly make yourself
 as slender as a young elephant
 so that you can descend quickly
 and alight on the rockery
 with the lovely peak just described
 before casting down into the house
 a glance of flickering lightning
 glowing so faintly that it resembles
 a twinkling line of fireflies.

Slim,
 youthful,
 with fine teeth,
 a lower lip like a ripe *bimba* fruit,
 a slender waist,
 eyes like a startled deer
 and a deep-set navel,
 moving lazily under the weight of her hips,
 and a little stooped because of her breasts—
 she may be there,
 as pristine as the almighty's first creation of womankind.
 You might recognize her thus.

2.79-80

2.80

But, with me, her companion, far away,
 the sweet-voiced girl, as dear to me as life,
 will be like a lonely *chakra-vaka* hen,*
 and with the passing of the days,
 their intense longing weighing her down,
 I think she will have changed,
 like a lotus laid waste by frost.

Doubtless her face,
 eyes swollen from intense crying,
 lower lip discolored by the heat of many sighs,
 will be resting in her hand,
 only partly visible behind her hanging tresses
 and as pale as the moon
 when your approach obscures its brilliance.

She will soon come into your view,
 absorbed in worship,
 or drawing an imaginary likeness of me
 wasted by separation,
 or asking the sweet-voiced mynah in its cage,
 ‘Gentle lady, perhaps you remember your master,
 for you are dear to him.’

Or, kind sir, she will have put a lute
 on her rag-clad lap,
 and, wanting to sing a song
 made of words that spell my name,
 she will somehow have managed
 to tune strings wet with tears,
 but will keep forgetting the melody,
 though she composed it herself.

Or she will be marking out
 the months that remain
 of the sentence that started the day I left
 by counting them with flowers
 placed on the threshold.
 Or she will be enjoying union—
 the action taking place in her mind.
 These are the usual diversions of women
 in separation from their lovers.

Over and over again
 your friend will be using
 her hand, its nails untrimmed,
 to brush aside from the curve
 of her hard, rough cheek
 the single braid of hair, painful to the touch,
 which I bound—without a garland—
 on the first day of our separation
 and which, at the end of the curse,
 my grief melted away, I am to untie.
 During the day, when she is busy,
 my absence will not trouble her too much.
 At night, when she has no diversions,
 I fear her grief will weigh more heavily upon her.
 So meet the worthy girl at midnight,
 when she is lying on the ground, awake,
 and, standing at the window of the house,
 console her with my message.

2.85

Wasted by anguish,
lying on one side
in her bed of separation,
she will look like the last slender sliver
of the moon on the eastern horizon.
Wondering how she might join me,
if only in a dream,
she will be longing for sleep,
the sting of her tears
stopping its arrival.

With a sigh scorching her bud-like lower lip,
she is sure to be scattering a tress
rough from being washed in water alone
and hanging down to her cheek.
On her bed of separation
she will be using hot tears
to get through the same night
that in my company
the pleasures of desire
would have made go by in an instant.

The rays of the moon,
 cool with the nectar of immortality,
 have entered through the windows,
 but no sooner does she,
 with the fondness of old,
 turn her eyes toward them
 than she draws them back,
 covering them with lashes
 weighed down by tears of sorrow,
 so that they look like a land-lotus
 on a cloudy day:
 neither open nor closed.

I know that your friend's heart
 is filled with love for me,
 which is how I can guess
 that she will be thus
 during our first separation.
 It's not just the pride
 of one lucky in love
 making me boastful:
 before long, brother,
 you will see for yourself
 all that I have described.

2.90

As she struggles to support
her delicate body,
which, shorn of adornment,
she has cast again and again
into the bosom of her bed,
the poor girl is sure to make you
shed tears of fresh water:
all those with tender hearts
tend to act with pity.

I expect that the eye of the doe-eyed girl—
its side-glances blocked by her locks,
its sheen of mascara missing,
the flirtatious furrowings of its brow
forgotten in her abstinence from wine—
will flicker upward when you draw near,
becoming as beautiful as a blue lily
fluttering in the wake of a fish.

Or perhaps, missing the scratches from my nails,
forced by the course of fate to cast off
its long-accustomed garland of pearls,
used to being massaged
by my hands after lovemaking,
pale like the trunk of a juicy banana tree,
her left thigh will be trembling.

If, o cloud, the dear girl is asleep then,
 sit near her and, for just one watch,
 wait without thundering,
 so that in her tight embrace
 with her lover, me,
 somehow found in a dream,
 her entwined creeper-like arms
 do not suddenly slip from my neck.

Wake her with a breeze
 cooled by your water's spray,
 and, when she and the fresh jasmine buds
 have been refreshed
 and she has fixed her gaze
 on the lightning-filled window
 occupied by you,
 start to address the proud lady
 in words gravely thundered:

2.95

'A dear friend of your husband—
 no, you are not a widow!—
 I am a cloud come to you
 bearing his messages in my heart.
 With deep, dulcet rumblings
 I make many weary travelers
 eager to untie their sweethearts' braids
 hurry along the road.'

After you say this,
with her head raised
and her heart swollen by longing,
she will look at you
and welcome you
as Sita did the son of the wind.*
Then, kind sir,
she will listen attentively,
because for a woman
news of her lover
delivered by a friend
is almost the same
as being with him.

At my bidding, good sir,
and to bring merit upon yourself,
please say the following:
‘Your companion is at a hermitage on Rama’s hill.
He is safe, dear lady,
and, being separated from you,
asks after your well-being—
the first thing to be wished for
of those prone to misfortune.

At far remove,
 his way blocked by unfriendly fate,
 he fancifully joins your body to his:
 yours skinny, his slender;
 yours tormented, his tortured;
 yours tear-drenched, his tearful;
 yours yearning endlessly, his yearnful;
 yours hot with sighs, his sighing still more.

Hungry for the touch of your face,
 he would love to whisper in your ear
 things that, in fact,
 could be said aloud
 in front of your friends.
 Now that he is beyond the range of your ears
 and invisible to your eyes,
 he tells you the following
 through my mouth,
 in words inspired by longing:

2.100

“I divine your limbs in *priyāngu* creepers,
 your glance in the look of a startled deer,
 the beauty of your cheek in the moon,
 your hair in the bunched tail feathers of peacocks,
 your flirtatious eyebrows in the slender ripples of a river...
 Oh alas, my darling!
 Your likeness is nowhere to be found
 all in one place.

When I paint you,
feigning anger,
in red dye on a rock,
as soon as I try to draw myself
falling at your feet,
tears keep welling up
and blur my sight.
Cruel fate cannot bear our union even there.

When I manage to find you
in the visions of my dreams
and stretch out my arms into space
in the hope of a tight embrace,
it is from none other than the watching earth-spirits
that teardrops as big as pearls
rain down on the trees' sprouting leaves.

Cool Himalayan breezes head south,
fragrant with the oozing sap of deodar trees
whose folded young leaves
they have just now burst open.
I embrace them, good lady—
they might have touched your body.

‘How might the nights,
with their long watches,
be shortened into instants?
And how might the day at all times
have but the gentlest warmth?’
O lady with darting eyes,
my mind, rendered helpless
by burning pangs of separation from you,
is set on impossible aims like these.

But, in thinking about many things,
I keep up my spirits all by myself,
so, good lady, you too
should not be overly worried.
Nobody’s lot is
permanent happiness
or constant sorrow:
fortunes rise and fall
like the rim of a wheel.

My curse will end when Vishnu
rises from his snake-bed:
close your eyes
and make the next four months go by.
Then, on nights lit by the autumn full moon,
the two of us shall enjoy
every one of those desires
that our separation intensified.”

He continued:

“Once you were asleep in bed,
clinging to my neck,
when for some reason you woke up,
crying out loud.
I kept asking you what was the matter.
You replied, stifling a laugh,
‘You cheat! In a dream I saw you
having fun with some other girl!’

Now that you have learned
from this token of remembrance
that I am well,
don’t let idle talk
make you distrustful of me,
o dark-eyed girl.
For some reason people say
that affections diminish in separation,
but frustration makes them
hungrier for what they want,
turning them into a store of love.”

I hope, kind sir, that you have decided
to carry out this task for me, your friend.
In no way do I consider your silence a refusal:
when asked, you give water to the *chátaka* birds without a
word,
for the good answer supplicants by doing what they want.

2.110

I am making you an unusual request.
Having done me this favor,
whether through friendship
or pity for me as one bereft,
wander where you wish, o cloud,
your beauty enhanced by the monsoon.
And may you never, even for an instant,
be separated like this from lightning!”*